PROJECT CASE STUDY
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# Sodaro Case Study

A Mobile Guide for Oakland Small Business Permits and Inspections

**CASE STUDY QUESTION** Can a simple mobile tool help Oakland business owners understand their next step and practice recognizing inspection examples?

## Project overview

Sodaro is a mobile-friendly project for Oakland small businesses and nonprofits. It focuses on two everyday needs: finding the steps to start a business and preparing for an inspection. The goal is to make city information easier to follow in plain language and connect users to official sources.

## The challenge

Owners may need to find permits, licenses, and inspection information across different city departments. It can be hard to know which step applies or what to do next. Sodaro is designed to bring the main steps together so owners can spend less time searching and feel more prepared.

## The prototype

**1. Business launch guide.** A step-by-step path helps users find likely permits, licenses, and next actions, with links to official information.

**2. Inspection photo practice.** The mobile demo is being designed so visitors can use a phone camera or upload one of three printed examples. Two examples show a failed condition and one shows a passing condition. The demo explains the example for learning.

## What I want to learn

The project has moved from a broad idea to these two focused features. The next test is to ask Oakland business owners to try the guide and photo activity. I want to learn whether they can find a useful next step, use the phone flow, and understand why a sample condition passes or fails. I also need feedback from an inspector or qualified code professional before relying on the inspection explanations.

## Current limits and next step

Sodaro is a design prototype, not a live city permit system or an official inspection tool. Its sample photos are for practice and cannot confirm whether a real business will pass inspection. The next step is to test the prototype with business owners, improve confusing parts, and review the guidance with qualified local experts.